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★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 43717.48 ▼ 110.58 0.25%

NASDAQ 20173.89 ▲ 1.2%

STOXX 600 515.83 ▼ 0.1%

10-YR. TREAS. yield 4.397%

OIL \$70.71 ▼ \$0.58

GOLD \$2,651.40 ▼ \$4.60

EURO \$1.0514

YEN 154.15

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Apollo CEO Marc Rowan's** brief consideration for the role of Treasury secretary in the coming Trump administration highlighted the lack of succession planning at his firm, an anomaly in the private-equity world. **A1**

◆ **Honeywell said it was** considering a potential separation of its aerospace business about a month after activist investor Elliott called for the industrial conglomerate to break itself up. **B1**

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** ended mixed, with the S&P 500 and Nasdaq advancing 0.4% and 1.2%, respectively, and the Dow retreating 0.3%. **B9**

◆ **Canal+'s shares fell** sharply as it started trading as a stand-alone company after a spinoff from French media group Vivendi. **B2**

◆ **CEOs of the world's** biggest companies are more optimistic about the economy than they have been in years, a survey found. **B1**

◆ **VW and labor leaders** resumed talks as they continue protracted negotiations over how to move forward with cost cuts across the automaker's domestic operations. **B3**

◆ **Novo Nordisk plans to** invest \$1.2 billion in a new production site for rare-disease medicines in Denmark. **B3**

◆ **Amazon union members** at a third U.S. facility voted to authorize a strike as tensions with the company intensify over contract negotiations. **B3**

◆ **Saga agreed to sell its** insurance-underwriting business to Ageas and to form a 20-year partnership with the Belgian insurer in a deal valued at the equivalent of \$186.1 million. **B9**

World-Wide

◆ **Islamist rebel leader** Abu Mohammed al-Jawhani swapped his military fatigues for a suit, positioning himself as a statesman who can unite Syria and responsibly manage relations with the country's neighbors. **A1**

◆ **Deposed Syrian leader** Bashar al-Assad, speaking out for the first time since his fall, said he stayed in the country until the regime's last defenses crumbled before being evacuated to Russia. **A8**

◆ **Two people were killed** and several were injured after a 15-year-old female student opened fire at a Christian school in Madison, Wis. **A3**

◆ **A New York judge** ruled that Trump's hush-money conviction remains valid, rejecting arguments from the president-elect that it should be dismissed on immunity grounds. **A6**

◆ **Trump and SoftBank** Chief Executive Masayoshi Son jointly announced that the investment company plans to pump at least \$100 billion into U.S. projects over the next four years. **A4**

◆ **Finance Minister Chrystia** Freeland quit Canada's Liberal government cabinet after publishing a stinging letter critical of Ottawa's direction on fiscal policy. **A9**

◆ **A Russian tanker split** apart in the Black Sea, spilling heavy fuel oil into the Kerch Strait, Russian maritime officials said. **A9**

◆ **Officials across the East Coast** are pushing the federal government for more answers about a wave of drone sightings, with some seeking local authority to shoot down the aircraft. **A3**

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Germany's Chancellor Loses Confidence Vote



FREDERIC KERN/IDP/ZUMA PRESS

LOW POINT: German Chancellor Olaf Scholz, center, on Monday lost a confidence vote, which he called to clear the way for the dissolution of parliament and early elections, following the unraveling of his coalition government. **A18**

Apollo Eyes Succession Plans After CEO Flirts With Politics

BY MIRIAM GOTTFRIED
AND ANNA MARIA ANDRIOTIS

Marc Rowan has remade Apollo Global Management during his nearly four years as its chief executive into a firm that manages more than \$700 billion in assets and is on a path to becoming a massive lender. The question facing the firm now: Would it be ready for life without him?

When Rowan, 62 years old, came back from a “semi-sabbatical” in 2021 to take the

helm from fellow co-founder and longtime CEO Leon Black, he told people he expected to do the job for five years or less, according to people familiar with the matter. That timeline has slipped because he is enjoying the job—so much so that he is expected to sign on for another five-year stint in the coming months, they said.

Still, the possibility of Rowan's imminent departure emerged last month when he became a top contender for

Treasury secretary under President-elect Donald Trump. Apollo and its advisers underwent preparations for his potential departure, the people said. Trump ultimately tapped investor Scott Bessent for the role, but the situation brought attention to the fact that Rowan has yet to spell out a clear succession plan.

Succession planning is serious business for private-equity firms. CEOs at Blackstone and KKR established heirs apparent years in advance to tele-

graph their intentions to stakeholders. Their goal has been to achieve as close to a seamless leadership transition as possible so as to avoid turnover among staff or clients. Given that, Rowan will likely identify a successor well ahead of any planned retirement.

At an investor conference last week in New York, the billionaire financier responded to a question about succession by highlighting the depth of Apollo's management team. *Please turn to page A4*

Albertsons Blames Kroger For Failed Merger

BY PATRICK THOMAS

Within months of Kroger announcing a \$20 billion deal to acquire rival Albertsons, Kroger made missteps that Albertsons said ultimately sank the supermarket megadeal.

A tie-up between the two largest U.S. grocery-store operators was bound to draw scrutiny from government antitrust watchdogs and consumers angry about rapidly climbing food prices. Albertsons officials now allege that Kroger's approach to the federal antitrust review further stacked the odds against the deal, which was blocked last week by a federal judge.

In court documents unsealed Monday that Albertsons filed in its suit against Kroger last week, Albertsons said Kroger showed reluctance to divest itself of a larger number of stores, a move aimed at preserving competition. Kroger executives ignored advice on how to assuage regulators' antitrust concerns and disregarded feedback about the deal from the Federal Trade Commission that could have potentially avoided a trial, Albertsons said.

Lawyers for Albertsons accused Kroger of losing interest in the deal after a pandemic-fueled surge in its profits began to cool and its stock price declined following the October 2022 merger announcement.

“Kroger derailed the merger after suffering a classic case of buyer's remorse,” according to the complaint, which seeks at least \$6 billion in damages. Albertsons filed the lawsuit in Delaware chan- *Please turn to page A2*

U.K. Clears Royal Mail Deal



CHRISTOPHER FURLONG/GETTY IMAGES

CZECH MATE: The U.K. struck a deal to allow Czech billionaire Daniel Kretinsky's EP Group to take over the owner of Royal Mail, keeping the storied postal service based in Britain. **B4**

The Big Fight Over a Tiny Truck That Isn't Fast or Ford Tough

Little Japanese haulers are winning fans; some states want them off American roads

BY SEAN MCLAIN

In the land of big trucks, a tiny pickup is stealing drivers' hearts. Now owners of the little haulers from Japan say they're being driven off the road.

Kei trucks are smaller than a Volkswagen Beetle and powered by an engine commonly found in motorcycles, but they have beds as large as a full-size pickup from Detroit. The combination of size and utility are virtues in their home country, where both land and natural resources are scarce.

Lately they have taken off in the U.S., where owners say they do nearly everything that bigger pickups can do and come with additional features—like being super sweet and making other drivers jealous. Even in states like Texas, where bigger is almost always

better, kei trucks are flying off lots.

At Tim Odom's dealership in Huffman, Texas, sales of kei trucks have exploded since he started importing them from Japan around five years ago. Odom says customers of Triple T Powersports, formerly Tim's Tiny Trucks, include hunters and outdoor enthusiasts who think American trucks are too darn big. “Let's be honest, most people aren't using these big trucks to the best of their capabilities,” Odom said. “They're going to Lowe's to pick up a piece of plywood.”

But many states are barring them from public motorways because regulators say they are too fragile to share the road with American-sized automobiles. Kei truck superfans say size prejudice is at play *Please turn to page A10*

Limits for Musk On SpaceX Secrets

Executives didn't seek higher security clearance for CEO to avoid questions

The payloads SpaceX launches into the heavens for the U.S. military and spy agencies are usually treated as a government secret,

By Joe Palazzolo,
Emily Glazer and
Micah Maidenber

shared only with select employees at the rocket company who hold special security clearances.

Elon Musk, its founder and chief executive, isn't one of them.

As SpaceX deepened its

ties with the national-security agencies in recent years, the company's lawyers advised senior executives not to seek a higher security clearance for Musk that would give him access to details about sensitive programs SpaceX is involved in, according to people familiar with the matter.

The reason, these people said, was that Musk would have had to answer questions from the government about his contacts with foreign nationals and drug use *Please turn to page A10*

◆ **Assad says he held out** until the end..... **A8**
◆ **Syrian Christians balance** hope and fear..... **A8**